UNIFORM DRESS CODE



Rajasthan education minister **Madan Dilawar** has declared that all schools, government and private, will have the same uniform, minus ties. The rationale: to curb 'visible inequality and arbitrary pricing'. But aren't school uniforms more than just outfits, lending an identity, a sense of belonging and pride? The irony here: Dilawar's department has been in the news for all the wrong reasons: school building collapses, lack of washrooms, teachers.... But the BJP minister isn't worried: next up, teaching lady teachers to "dress modestly", and salary cuts for those who don't sing the national anthem and song daily.

Conflicting Symbols



The **Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS)** in Telangana is miffed that the Election Commission is handing out such a deluge of symbols that their 'car' could "easily be mistaken" and get drowned in the crowd. Some of the symbols in question for the November 11 assembly bypoll to the prestigious Jubilee Hills seat: the 'chapati roller', bagged by the Alliance of Democratic Reforms Party; the 'camera' of the Praja Velugu Party; and the AIMIM's 'ship'. How any of them would resemble the BRS's 'Ambassador' is anybody's guess. In all, the bypoll will see 58 candidates flaunting everything, from a pressure cooker to a briefcase, from grapes to a gas cylinder.

IN A MOOD FOR JUGGLERY



As part of a grand bureaucratic game of musical chairs, the **Mamata Banerjee** government in West Bengal just swapped 527 officers in one go, including over a dozen district magistrates, all timed just as the Election Commission launched its roll-revision blitz. The Trinamool Congress regime says it's just spring cleaning; critics say it's a tactical reshuffle ahead of the big electoral vaudeville show. With the administrative realignment accomplished, whispers are that the police cadre are next. Still, with new faces at the helm, Bengalis will be hoping there is some positive change in their lives too.

Kaushik Deka with Avaneesh Mishra, Ajay Sukumaran, Rohit Parihar and Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

HEALTH WATCH

By **Sonali Acharjee**

THE TOXIC TRUTH
REUSED OIL IS HAZARDOUS

The National Human Rights Commission has asked the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) and the health ministry for a state-wise action taken report after finding "widespread" reuse of cooking oil by roadside vendors and eateries—a practice it calls a serious threat to public health. The notice highlights the reuse of dark, foamy or overheated oil and demands tighter checks on how such oil is being disposed of or reintroduced into the food chain.



Science strongly supports these health hazard fears. A 2023 study in peer-reviewed international journal *Foods* found that reheated oils generate harmful aldehydes and trans fats that trigger oxidative stress and inflammation in the liver and blood vessels. Another 2023 paper in *Environmental Science and Pollution Research* reported that repeatedly heated oil elevates markers of liver injury, raises 'bad' cholesterol (LDL) and can damage kidney tissue. Similarly, a 2022 study in *Nutrition & Metabolism* showed that ingesting oxidised oil compounds can lead to insulin resistance and early signs of heart disease and diabetes.

When oil reaches its smoking point, it begins to degrade rapidly, forming free radicals and toxic compounds. Even oil that hasn't smoked accumulates harmful residues with reuse. FSSAI's RUCO (Repurpose Used Cooking Oil) guidelines advise discarding or recycling such oil instead of returning it to the kitchen.

Yet, cost is a major factor—edible oil prices have risen sharply in recent years. Public health experts are also warning about India's high per capita transfat exposure, linked to deep-fried snacks and reused oils. Oils with higher smoking points, such as refined sunflower, rice bran, mustard and groundnut oil, are considered relatively safer.